

MINUTES OF MEETING HELD October 20th 2025 OF GRADUATE AND PROFESSIONAL STUDENT COUNCIL, GENERAL COUNCIL

A meeting of the Graduate and Professional Student Council (GPSC), General Council (GC) was convened on Monday, October 20th at 6:00 PM held in the El Portal Building Conference room and Zoom.

1. Call to Order

Present at the meeting were the following members of the:

- **(6) GPSC Executive Board (EB):** Mourad Abdennebi (President), Naama Levy (Administrative Vice President), Travis Dean (Executive Vice President), Mehrdad Aghayari (Assembly Chair), Milad Hasankhani (Treasurer), Rishabh Bhattad (Secretary)
- **(20) GPSC General Council (GC):** Anna Roche - proxy for Ryan, Harriet Olulo, Anam Rani Khaldi, Max Thomas, Kinsey Cline, Ella Stephan, Joanna Joseph, Mohamadreza Ramenazi, Breanne Harvey, John Conley, Theodore Lowell, Xuelun Tian, J Bryce Palmer, Matt Sandoval, Amanda Chriswell, Precious Innocent Mastala, Holly Thomas, Lucia Luna Aurelia, Hannah Szoke - proxy for Esha, Manglam Srivastav.
- **(3) Advisors and Staff:** Solange Quintana , Elham Chelabi, Roselyn Amamoo.

Quorum met: 26 Officers present

2. Call to Audience

The GC may not discuss items that are not on the agenda. Therefore, action taken as a result of public comment will be limited to directing staff to study the matter or scheduling the matter for consideration at a later date.

3. Review and Approve Meeting Minutes

The minutes from the previous meeting (September 15, 2025) were reviewed and approved.

4. Officer Reports

- **President (Mourad Abdennebi):**
 - Thanked officers and representatives for their continued advocacy and feedback.
 - Reported the university declined the Higher Education Compact but remains open to dialogue.
 - Noted slow but positive progress on various projects and undertaking which GPSC is pursuing such as stipend increases, counseling fee elimination/access, and basic needs expansion.
- **Administrative Vice President (Naama Levy):**



- Worked with the EB on the response to the compact decision.
- Continued work on internal GPSC structure and organization, including the GPSC activity tracker for transparency which is now available for all GPSC members to keep track of the progress made on the projects and undertakings by GPSC.
- **Executive Vice President (Travis Dean):**
 - Nothing to report.
- **Treasurer (Milad Hasankhani):**
 - Working with Graduate College and new Admin Consultant (Katie) to clarify budget status.
- **Assembly Chair (Mehrdad Aghayari):**
 - Nothing to report.
- **Secretary (Rishabh Bhattad):**
 - Nothing to report.

5. Internal Committee Reports

- **Policy and Legislative Action (Elham Chelabi):**
 - The Policy Committee discussed scenarios and future actions (funding campaigns, identifying affected students) regarding the compact.
 - Noted public comment period open for policy change affecting international student status duration.
- **Appropriations and Grants (Roselyn Amamoo):**
 - Travel and PPG grant cycle closed Oct 16th; reviewers assigned Oct 17th.
 - The first review phase is expected to end Oct 24th.
 - Appropriations Committee meeting to follow review to set funding cutoffs.
- **Governing Documents (Travis Dean):**
 - The committee is developing a "digestible" guide to Robert's Rules of Order and making motions to help new representatives.
 - The committee is preparing Google Doc versions of the Constitution, Bylaws, and Election Code to be shared with the General Council, allowing all representatives to comment and provide feedback for future amendments.
- **Marketing, Communications and Social Activities (Solange Quintana):**
 - Initiated planning meetings for Cap & Gown program (inventory, dry cleaning).
 - Planning the October social halloween event which is expected to happen on 30th October.
 - Social media management and newsletter distribution is going as usual.
- **Professional Development (Naama Levy):**
 - A motion was introduced to discuss restructuring the Professional Development committee. The rationale provided was that many of its traditional functions (workshops, etc.) are redundant with existing university offerings and that committee efforts could be better served elsewhere, such as by forming a grievance process for students facing mistreatment that doesn't meet the threshold for formal university action or by being an adhoc committee which take tasks and undertaking as needed from other committees and person to

lessen the burden on them and to support GPSC functions.

- **VOTE:** A motion to restructure the Professional Development Committee was put to a vote.
- **OUTCOME:** The motion **passed** by a majority with 22 votes in favor. (Further discussion on the new focus to follow).

6. Old Business

- **Writing Skills Improvement Program (WSIP):** President provided an update, noting the Graduate College has agreed to find a model integrating the WSIP with the Graduate Writing Lab. The next step is to form a task force of interested individuals to help find a new model. Representatives interested in joining this task force were asked to come forward.

7. New Business & Action Items

- **Special Election:** The council held a special election for two vacant representative seats: Danaika Dorsainvil (R. Ken Coit College of Pharmacy Rep) and Allison Colvard (College of Nursing Rep). Both candidates provided brief statements on their background and involvement on the Phoenix and Gilbert campuses. The council then moved to an executive session for discussion and voting. Both candidates were approved by majority with 27 votes in favor and subsequently sworn in as official GPSC representatives.
- **GPSC organization-wide activity tracker:** AVP Naama Levy and President Mourad Abdennebi introduced the new activity tracker. It was explained as a transparent, centralized document for all representatives to see what projects GPSC is working on, the progress of each, and who is involved. The tracker will be shared with the council.
- **Constituency survey results:** AVP Naama Levy shared the initial results of the constituent concern survey (40+ responses). She highlighted the ranked priorities (page 13 of the results) as a good indicator of student concerns and noted an updated file would be emailed.
- **Follow-up information on the Compact:** President reported on his meeting with the university president. The university's official response is to **decline** the proposed compact, re-emphasizing merit-based funding principles. However, the university remains open to dialogue. Next steps will depend on the White House response, and GPSC may call for a campus-wide conversation.
- **Increase affordability of Graduate Healthcare Plans:** This long-term goal (including no-cost counseling, dental, vision, dependent coverage) was brought for discussion. President Abdennebi noted progress on no-cost counseling and an embedded counselor. SHIAC committee members (Ben and Holly) provided context that dependent coverage is likely not feasible due to state/university-wide plan rules, as it would drastically increase premiums for all students. Partial/routine dental and vision coverage is more plausible, but numbers are pending. After discussion, the item was **postponed** pending more information.



- **Increase Graduate Assistant (GA) Stipends:** The proposed framework from the Provost's Office, which ties minimum stipend increases to the university's calculated "cost of attendance" percentage, was discussed. A key concern was raised by EVP Travis Dean that if colleges are not given new funds, this mandate could force them to cut the number of GA positions to fund the increase for remaining GAs. Due to these unanswered questions, the item was **postponed** for further clarification from leadership.
- **Increase Mental Health Access:** This item, related to the healthcare goal, was discussed. The priority is to secure embedded counselors at the Graduate Center. The Graduate College does not have funds, but the Provost and Student Affairs are working to fund at least one counselor from CAPS for the spring semester. It was agreed to invite Cassandra from Health Promotion to the next meeting. No formal vote was taken.
- **International Student Fund Creation:** Director Chelabi presented the proposal to create a dedicated fund (for basic needs, legal support, etc.) for international students. Strong support was voiced, noting the gap in legal resources. A motion to establish the International Student Fund was put to vote. The motion **passed** by a majority with 20 votes in favor.
- **GPSC Event - Graduate Showcase:** The proposal to bring back the Student Showcase, with \$15,000 in earmarked award funding from the Office of Research, was discussed. The total cost of organising is estimated at \$30k, requiring fundraising, and the timeline is tight (Spring 2026). Concerns were raised by reps about whether this was the best use of funds vs. grants. It was clarified that the \$15k is earmarked and cannot be moved. The item was **postponed** for the next GC meeting to get more information from the Office of Research.
- **GPSC Collaborations - Fall Break Community Dinner:** President Abdennebi proposed collaborating with ASUA and other departments on a "Gratitude Dinner" (or Friendsgiving) for students. The event would be externally funded (\$2k from ISS, \$5k from Grad College, etc.). A motion to collaborate on the community dinner event was put to vote. The motion **passed** by majority with 24 votes in favor. Volunteers were requested and rep. Reza, Ella, Precious and Manglam volunteered for the planning committee.

8. Constituency Concerns

- No constituency concerns were raised.

9. Motion to Adjourn

- Motion to adjourn the meeting by Mehrdad:
 - Seconded by Reza.
 - The meeting was adjourned at 7:33 pm.



THE UNIVERSITY OF ARIZONA

Graduate & Professional
Student Council

Graduate and Professional Student Council Executive Board

Rishabh Bhattad, Secretary